



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

A HOME destroyed by the Eaton fire on Palm Street in Altadena, a town that served as an enclave for artists and independent thinkers.

U.S. ARMY CORPS BEGINS DEBRIS CLEANUP

Newsom calls pace of clearing the Eaton and Palisades fire zones ‘unprecedented.’

BY LAURA J. NELSON AND JULIA WICK

In a pivotal milestone in Los Angeles County’s long road to recovery from the deadly wildfires in early January, the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers on Tuesday began clearing debris from burned properties in Altadena and Pacific Palisades.

The cleanup marks the start of a years-long rebuilding process for thousands of Californians who lost homes and businesses in the Eaton and Palisades fires. More than 9,400 structures were destroyed in Altadena, and more than 6,800 in Pacific Palisades.

The cleanup will be a massive logistical operation, with thousands of contractors from the Army Corps and private firms working to dispose of as much as 4.5 million tons of fire debris, more than 10 times as much as from the fire that devastated Maui in 2023.

Gov. Gavin Newsom said federal, state and local officials had worked to hack through “bureaucratic thickets” to speed L.A.’s cleanup and recovery process. Debris clearance beginning 35 days after the wildfire was twice as fast as the timeline after the 2018 Woolsey fire, which destroyed more than 1,600 homes in the Thousand Oaks, Oak Park, Agoura Hills and Malibu areas.

“This is unprecedented in California history,” Newsom said at a news conference Tuesday morning in Altadena, alongside Maj. Gen. Jason Kelly of the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers and other state and local officials.

Surrounded by blocks of wreckage, the group stood in [See Cleanup, A6]

Will Altadena hold on to its spirit after a rebuild?

Some residents wonder if they should stay following the fire



JULIANA YAMADA Los Angeles Times

GOV. GAVIN NEWSOM speaks at a news conference at Odyssey Charter School ahead of the cleanup process that began Tuesday.

BY COLLEEN SHALBY

Miles Loudermilk’s family home survived the Eaton fire. But the neighborhood he grew up in was destroyed. The smell of toxic smoke has lingered in Altadena and homes still standing on West Terrace Street have been boarded up as residents stay away.

His parents are in their 70s; they never considered moving. But a month after a fire tore through their town, Loudermilk’s family and other residents have found themselves at a crossroads over whether to stay and rebuild their community, or leave.

“The landscape around the area is just decimated. We don’t know if that’s going to be looking that way for the next two or three, four, five, 10 years,” Loudermilk, 54, said.

“Altadena is not for sale” has become a rallying cry throughout neighborhoods. A growing number of yard signs dot the burned area where [See Altadena, A6]

A standard-bearer for academic gains

Compton Unified’s focus on addressing students’ weak spots has raised test scores.

BY HOWARD BLUME

The Compton Unified School District is winning recognition for its success with students, who are showing significant, long-term academic improvement that is outpacing growth in California and the nation.

An analysis of recent standardized test scores shows Compton has proved to be a standout exception

to overall poor math and reading test scores — even though its overall student proficiency rates have much room to grow.

In recent years, Compton Unified teachers have intently studied how students are performing on tests and targeted lessons to weak spots. The district — where nearly all students come from low-income families — also brings in corps of tutors who walk the class and offer on-the-spot help. And teacher training in math and reading has been bolstered.

When compared with other districts with similar demographics, Compton is among several that have [See Compton, A8]



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

FROYLAN DIAZ, an honors math student at Compton High School, said it was hard to get back on track academically after the COVID-19 pandemic emergency.

Bad flu season getting worse in state

Officials report surge in hospitalizations and at least 10 deaths among children.

BY RONG-GONG LIN II

The worst flu season in years is swamping California, prompting a renewed surge in hospitalizations as officials warn the disease could continue circulating at high levels for weeks to come.

By one measure, this season has already been more potent than any seen since the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic in early 2020, according to data from the California Department of Public Health. The rate at which flu tests returned positive results at the state’s clinical sentinel labs surged to 27.8% for the week ending Feb. 1, the most recent for which complete data are available.

That’s higher than the peak of the “triple-demic” winter of 2022-23, when California’s hospitals were stressed by simultaneous high circulation of flu, COVID and respiratory syncytial virus, or RSV.

“We’re still on the way up,” Dr. Peter Chin-Hong, an infectious-disease expert at UC San Francisco, said of flu. Since the pandemic began, he said, “this is the first time that we’re mainly talking about flu rather than COVID.”

There have been at least 10 pediatric flu deaths this season in California, according to data from the Department of Public Health. That includes three teenagers in San Diego County.

“These recent flu deaths among our youth are tragic and concerning as we head into what historically is the peak of flu season,” Dr. Ankita Kadakia, the county’s interim public health officer, said in a statement.

None of the teens had received a flu vaccine, which Kadakia said remains “the [See Flu, A11]

Jordan responds to Gaza plan

King Abdullah II warns Trump against the mass expulsion of Palestinians. **NATION, A5**

What to expect from major storm

Forecasters warn of possible debris flows in burn areas and flooded roads. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Trump casts chill over Hollywood

Films’ fates illustrate a muting of resistance to his actions so far this term. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather

Rain and drizzle. L.A. Basin: 54/53. **B6**

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